



Drew Paine

User experience, product and software in science.

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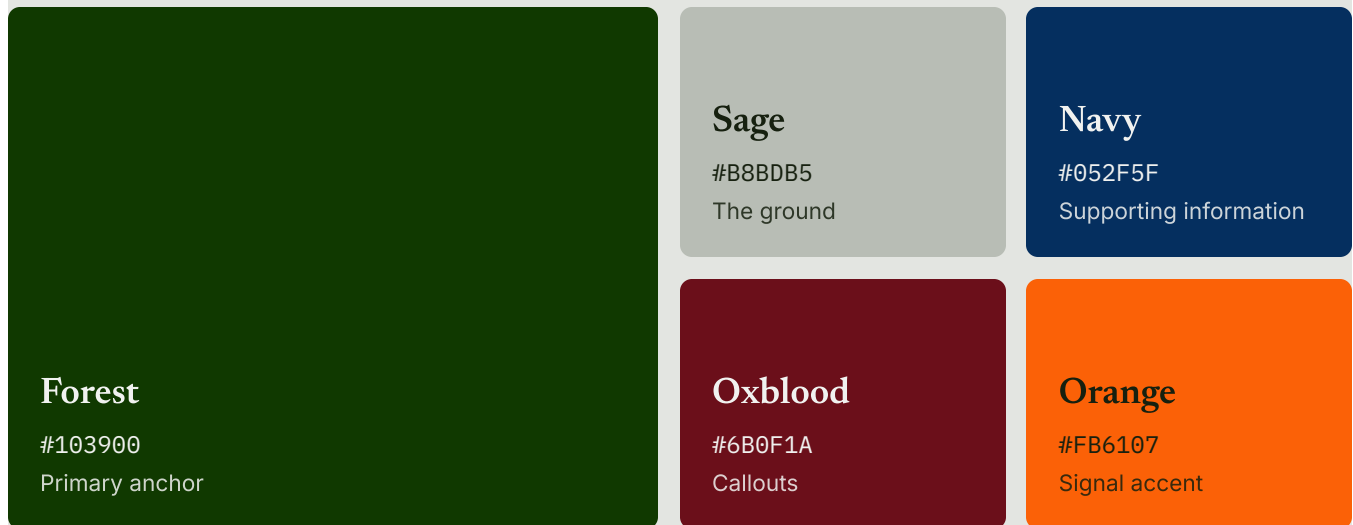
Overview

The visual identity for drewpaine.net: a personal site and blog about user experience, product work and software in science. It should feel like a well-kept lab notebook: calm sage paper, forest-green ink, and a few precise marks of color where something matters.

Content fundamentals

- **Voice.** Plain, direct and specific. Write the way a knowledgeable researcher talks to a colleague from another field. Prefer "how scientists do research with software" over "leveraging computational paradigms".
- **Person.** Bios and author notes are third person ("Drew Paine is...", "Dr. Paine advocates..."). Posts may use first person.
- **Casing.** Page titles and role titles in Title Case ("Lead Product & User Experience Architect"). Post titles in Title Case. Labels (label style) in UPPERCASE.
- **Names and acronyms.** Spell an organization out on first use and put its acronym in parentheses, linked: "Scientific Data Division (SciData)", "Better Scientific Software (BSSw)". Use the acronym alone after that.
- **Ampersands.** Use & in role and group names ("Product & User Experience"), "and" in sentences.
- **Email.** Always written out so bots can't collect it: `pained - at - lbl - dot - gov`. Never a `mailto:` link.
- **No emoji**, no exclamation marks in headings, no filler ("Welcome to my blog!").

Color



The brand palette is five colors. Light-theme tokens use them exactly; the dark theme lifts the three dark hues so they stay legible.

BRAND COLOR	HEX	TOKEN	ROLE
Forest	#103900	forest	Primary anchor: headings, links, nav, buttons
Sage	#B8BDB5	sage (tinted for surface)	The ground: page background, sidebars, rules
Navy	#052F5F	navy, focus	Supplementary information, focus ring
Oxblood	#6B0F1A	oxblood	Callouts: the one thing on a page to notice
Orange	#FB6107	orange	Signal accent, in small amounts

Rules:

- Paint the page with `surface` (Sage lightened toward white). Put raised blocks on `surface-raised`. Never use pure white or pure black.
- Set body text in `ink` and bylines and captions in `ink-muted`. Both pass 4.5:1 on every ground in both themes.
- Make `forest` the dominant hue. Every page title, heading and link is `forest`. A primary button is a `forest` fill with `on-forest` text.
- Use `sage` at full strength only for sidebar grounds and `line` rules. It is too close to `surface` to separate anything on its own, so pair it with `space` or a heading.
- Use `oxblood` only in callouts (`oxblood` border and title on `oxblood-soft`). One callout per screen at most, so it stays meaningful.
- Use `navy` for sidebar titles and the `focus` ring. It marks "supporting" rather than "important".

- Use orange for marks, not text, in the light theme: link underlines, the active-nav bar, a short rule above a label. It is 2.4:1 on surface, so it must never carry meaning or be body text there. On a forest fill it may be large text (24px+). In the dark theme it is 5.9:1 and may be text.
- Keep it to Forest plus one other hue per component. Callouts are Oxblood, sidebars are Navy on Sage, and nothing combines all five.

Color tokens

TOKEN	LIGHT	DARK	USAGE
surface	 #e3e5e1	 #121710	Page background. Light is Sage tinted 60% toward white; dark is a green-black.
surface-raised	 #f1f2f0	 #1b2218	Author bio, blog entries on hover, any block that sits above the page.
sage	 #b8bdb5	 #3b4337	Palette grey. Sidebar ground and strong dividers. Light value is the brand Sage exactly.
line	 #b8bdb5	 #3b4337	Hairline rules under the nav, post header and between blog entries. Decorative only.
ink	 #16200f	 #e4e8e0	Body text on surface, surface-raised, sage, forest-soft and oxblood-soft (8.3:1 or higher in both themes).
ink-muted	 #434b3f	 #a9b1a4	Bylines, dates, captions. On surface and surface-raised (6.8:1+), and on sage (4.7:1 light, 4.65:1 dark).
forest	 #103900	 #9fcb80	Primary anchor. Headings, links, nav, primary buttons. Light value is the brand Forest exactly; 10.3:1 on surface. Dark theme lifts it to stay legible.
forest-soft	 #d8e2d0	 #1d2c14	Tinted ground for a selected or highlighted row. Forest and ink both read on it.
on-forest	 #f1f2f0	 #121710	Text and icons on a forest fill (11.6:1 light, 9.8:1 dark).
orange	 #fb6107	 #fb6107	Signal accent, used sparingly. Light theme: decoration only (link underlines, active-nav bar, rule marks) because it is 2.4:1 on surface; large text only on a forest fill (4.2:1). Dark theme: may be text (5.9:1 on surface).
oxblood	 #6b0f1a	 #e8939c	Callout border and heading. Light value is the brand Oxblood exactly; 9.9:1 on oxblood-soft.
oxblood-soft	 #f2e4e5	 #2e1417	Callout ground.
navy	 #052f5f	 #93b8e6	Sidebar headings and supplementary information. Light value is the brand Navy exactly; 7.0:1 on sage light, 5.0:1 dark.
focus	 #052f5f	 #fb6107	Keyboard focus ring, 2px solid with 2px offset. 6.9:1+ on every light ground; 3.3:1+ on every dark ground.

Type

Three Google Fonts families, each with one job:

- **Newsreader** (serif) for the name, titles, headings and the lede. Weight 600 for headings, 400 italic for the lede.
- **Inter** (sans) for all running text, nav and buttons. A neutral, highly readable screen face that lets the serif headings carry the personality.
- **IBM Plex Mono** (mono) for bylines, dates and uppercase labels: the "metadata" voice, like a lab notebook's margin notes.

Load them with:

```
<link rel="preconnect" href="https://fonts.googleapis.com">
<link rel="preconnect" href="https://fonts.gstatic.com" crossorigin>
<link rel="stylesheet" href="https://fonts.googleapis.com/css2?family=Inter:ital,opsz,wght@0,14..32,400;0,14..32,700;1,14..32,400&family=IBM+Plex+Mono:wght@400;500&family=Newsreader:ital,opsz,wght@0,6..72,400;0,6..72,600;1,6..72,400&display=swap">
```

- Use the type styles as given: display for the home page name only, h1 for page and post titles, h2 for sections and blog entry titles, h3 for sub-sections and box titles, lede under a post title, body for text, body-small inside boxes, byline for author and date lines, label for uppercase eyebrows.
- Under 600px, step display to 36px and h1 to 32px. Other sizes stay.
- Keep running text to the measure (68ch). Give headings text-wrap: balance.
- Bold (700) within body for emphasis; don't set whole sentences in italic Inter.

Type styles

display

Headings · 48px / 52px · 600

Home page name only. 36px under 600px wide.

Drew Paine, PhD

h1

Headings · 40px / 46px · 600

Page and post titles. 32px under 600px wide.

Software as a Scientific Instrument

h2

Headings · 28px / 34px · 600

Section headings, blog entry titles.

Lead Product & User Experience Architect

h3

Headings · 22px / 28px · 600

Sub-sections, callout and sidebar titles.

Why developer experience matters

lede

Headings · 21px / 32px · 400

italic

The one- or two-sentence summary under a post title.

Scientists build software to do research, and that software shapes the science.

body

Text · 18px / 29px · 400

All running text.

Drew Paine is a Lead Product & User Experience Architect in the Scientific Data Division at Lawrence Berkeley National Laboratory.

body-small

Text · 16px / 24px · 400

Sidebars, author bio, blog entry summaries.

Short related notes that sit beside the main text.

byline

Meta · 14px / 20px · 400

Author and date lines, footer copyright.

By Drew Paine, PhD · September 28, 2026

label

Meta · 12px / 16px · 500

Uppercase labels above boxes and sections. Always uppercase.

ABOUT THE AUTHOR

Layout and spacing

- Center one content column at content-width (70% of the window), widening to content-width-narrow (90%) at the 600px breakpoint. Never let the page scroll sideways.
- Space with the 4px-based scale: space-4 inside boxes on phones, space-6 inside boxes on desktop, space-8 around boxes and between blog entries, space-12 between page sections.
- Separate sections with space and a 1px hairline, not with boxes. Only callouts, sidebars and the author bio get a background.
- Corners: radius-md on boxes, radius-sm on buttons, radius-round on photos. No shadows.

Spacing scale

	space-1	4px	Gap between label and heading.
	space-2	8px	Byline to text, nav underline offset.
	space-3	12px	Gap between social links.
	space-4	16px	Box padding on phones, minimum side gutter.
	space-6	24px	Box padding, gap between nav items and between photo and text.
	space-8	32px	Space above and below callouts, between blog entries.
	space-12	48px	Space between page sections.
	space-16	64px	Space above the footer.
	radius-sm	2px	
	radius-md	6px	
	radius-round	50%	

Links and focus

- Links are forest, underlined with a 2px orange underline at 3px offset. On hover the underline turns forest. Visited links stay forest.
- Every interactive element shows a 2px solid focus outline at 2px offset on keyboard focus. Never remove it.

Iconography and imagery

- There is no logo. Set the name "Drew Paine, PhD" in Newsreader 600 wherever a mark is needed.
- No icon set. Use text labels and arrows (→) instead of icons. No emoji.
- Photos are round (radius-round), with alt text naming the person and year ("Headshot of Drew Paine, PhD from 2026").

Components

Site nav

Home **Blog**

The navigation bar at the top of every page.

Provide: a short list of links (currently Home and Blog), with `aria-current="page"` on the link for the current page.

Styling: centered row, space-6 apart, bold sans in forest, no underline. The current page gets a 3px orange bar beneath it; hover shows the bar in line. A line rule runs under the whole nav.

Don't: add more than five links, icons, or a hamburger menu. The site is small enough to show everything.

Blog entry

Software as a Scientific Instrument

By Drew Paine, PhD · September 28, 2026

Scientists build software to do research, and that software shapes the science.
What changes when we design it that way?

Read more →

One post's summary on the blog page, linking to the full post.

Provide: the post title and URL, author, date, and the post's lede as a one- or two-sentence summary. On the site the blog page generates these from each post's front matter.

Styling: title in h2 as a forest link with no underline (orange underline on hover), byline in ink-muted, summary in body-small, then a bold "Read more →" link. space-6 vertical padding and a line rule below each entry.

Don't: add thumbnails, tags or excerpts longer than two sentences. The list should scan quickly, newest first.

Callout

Usability is a research outcome

Software that scientists can actually use is what turns an algorithm into a scientific instrument. Budget for user research the way you budget for testing.

A full-width highlighted box for the one point on a page readers must not miss.

Provide: a short title (h3) and one or two sentences of body text. On the site, write it in a post as `{% callout "Title" %}{...{% endcallout %}}`.

Styling: oxblood-soft ground, 1px oxblood border, radius-md, space-6 padding (space-4 under 600px), title in oxblood, text in ink. space-8 above and below. Clears any floated sidebar.

Use it for: a key takeaway, a warning, or a quote that carries the post's argument.

Don't: use more than one per screen, put a sidebar inside it, or use it for decoration. If everything is a callout, nothing is.

Sidebar

Research software engineers sit between domain science and professional software practice. Their work is often invisible in publications, even when the results depend on it. Recognizing that work starts with naming it, which is why communities like US-RSE matter.

DEFINITION

Research software engineer

Someone who develops and maintains software used in research, often inside a lab or facility.

A box of supporting notes that floats beside the main text on desktop and runs full width on phones.

Provide: an optional label (e.g. "Definition", "Further reading"), a short h3 title and a few sentences or a short list. On the site, write it in a post as `{% sidebar "Title" %}...{% endsidebar %}`, placed just before the paragraph it should sit beside.

Styling: sage ground, radius-md, space-4 × space-6 padding, body-small text in ink, label in ink-muted, title in navy. Floats right at 35% of the column with space-6 left margin; under 600px it stops floating.

Use it for: definitions, background, related links, or a fact the main argument doesn't need.

Don't: put anything essential in a sidebar (readers skip them), place two sidebars in a row, or use it where a callout is meant.

Author bio



ABOUT THE AUTHOR

Drew Paine, PhD is a Lead Product & User Experience Architect in the Scientific Data Division at Lawrence Berkeley National Laboratory. He studies how scientists do research with software.

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The author block that closes every blog post.

Provide: the author's photo, name, a bio of two or three sentences in third person, and an email written out (name - at - domain - dot - tld). On the site these come from `src/_data/authors.json`; the post layout renders the block.

Styling: surface-raised ground, radius-md, space-6 padding and gap. 96px photo with radius-round, then the label "About the author" in ink-muted, the name in bold, the bio in body-small, and the email in byline style. Under 600px the photo stacks above the text and everything centers.

Don't: use a `mailto:` link, a photo that isn't square, or a bio longer than about 60 words.